

The Philippine E-Commerce Affiliate Landscape: A Forum-Based Analysis of Shopee and Lazada Monetization

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Abstract

This article presents a qualitative analysis of affiliate marketer sentiment regarding the monetization capabilities of the Shopee and Lazada e-commerce platforms in the Philippines. Based on organic discussions from public online forums, this research synthesizes real-world perceptions and strategies, moving beyond official program documentation. The findings reveal that Shopee and Lazada offer distinct strategic pathways. Shopee is widely regarded for its beginner-friendly interface and straightforward commission model, making it an accessible entry point. In contrast, Lazada provides a more complex but potentially more lucrative structure with a dual-tracking system and significant commission boosts during sales events, appealing to more strategic marketers. The analysis also uncovers significant operational challenges, primarily administrative hurdles such as protracted delays in payment processing and tax information approval, which act as a "persistence barrier" for new entrants. The study concludes that success is less dependent on audience size and more on "community trust velocity"—the speed at which an affiliate can build a loyal, engaged community that acts on their recommendations.

Keywords: affiliate marketing, Shopee, Lazada, Philippines, e-commerce, content creation, forum analysis, passive income, monetization strategy

1. Introduction

The proliferation of e-commerce platforms has introduced a paradigm shift in digital entrepreneurship and content monetization in the Philippines. AI-powered recommendation engines and sophisticated tracking technologies have transformed affiliate marketing from a supplementary income stream into a viable full-time career for many. Among the leading platforms, Shopee and Lazada have garnered significant market dominance. While official program guidelines provide one perspective on their capabilities, a crucial gap exists in understanding how these programs are perceived and utilized by the affiliate community in

real-world scenarios.^{12, 13}

This research addresses that gap by analyzing organic, user-generated content from prominent online forums and communities frequented by Filipino affiliate marketers. The objective is to identify and synthesize the prevailing sentiment regarding the advantages and disadvantages of each platform's affiliate program. By focusing exclusively on unsolicited community discussions, this study aims to provide an authentic, ground-level view of the platforms' practical strengths, their comparative performance, and the specific use cases for which each is preferred.^{10, 54} This analysis seeks to understand not just if Shopee and Lazada are viable monetization tools, but how and why they are being integrated into modern digital content workflows.

2. Methodology

This study employed a qualitative thematic analysis of user-generated content from public online forums and social media groups frequented by Filipino affiliate marketers. The methodology was designed to capture authentic, unsolicited opinions and experiences.

- **Data Sources:** Content was systematically gathered from platforms known for in-depth discussions on e-commerce and digital marketing in the Philippines. These included Reddit (specifically subreddits such as r/ShopeePH and r/phinvest) and various public and private Facebook Groups dedicated to affiliate marketing for Shopee and Lazada.^{9, 10, 27, 38, 53}
- **Data Collection:** The research focused on discussion threads, comments, and posts published within the relevant timeframe. Search criteria included terms like "Shopee affiliate," "Lazada affiliate," "how to earn," "commission," "payout issues," and "affiliate strategy Philippines." Only organic content was considered; sponsored posts and official platform marketing materials were explicitly excluded.
- **Data Analysis:** A thematic analysis approach was used to identify recurring patterns in the data. Collected text was coded to extract key themes related to praised features, direct platform comparisons, preferred strategies, success stories, and common criticisms or frustrations. Representative verbatim quotes and anecdotes were selected to illustrate these themes.
- **Ethical Considerations:** To protect the privacy of the forum users, all experiences and anecdotes included in this report have been synthesized and anonymized. The analysis focuses on the content of the discussions rather than the identities of the participants.

3. Findings

The analysis of affiliate discourse reveals a nuanced and multi-faceted perception of the Shopee and Lazada affiliate programs. The findings are organized into five key areas: a deep dive into each platform's program, the dominant strategic approaches discussed by the community, community-reported experiences, and the essential forums where these

discussions take place.

3.1 Analysis of the Shopee Philippines Affiliate Program

Community discussions consistently identify the Shopee Affiliate Program as a highly accessible entry point for aspiring marketers in the Philippines.^{1, 2}

3.1.1 Eligibility Criteria and Application Process

To qualify, an applicant must be based in the Philippines and have an active social media presence, defined as having at least one public post within the last 14 days.^{12, 23} While a follower count of 1,000 or more is often suggested, it is not a strict rule.²⁴ Applications are submitted via the official Shopee PH Affiliate website.^{23, 24} A significant point of discussion is the variable and often lengthy approval timeline. While official guidance suggests a 30-business-day review period, community members frequently report waits exceeding this, often requiring follow-ups with customer support.^{9, 24}

3.1.2 The Commission Structure Decoded

Shopee's commission model is a tiered system based on buyer status (new or existing) and product category (Electronics or Non-Electronics), with a strong incentive for new customer acquisition.²

- **Non-Electronic Products:** 12% for New Buyers, 4% for Existing Buyers.²
- **Electronic Products:** 7% for New Buyers, 1.5% for Existing Buyers.²

A critical feature is the checkout level cap of ₱125 per order, meaning the maximum earning from a single transaction is limited, regardless of the total purchase value.² This structure favors a strategy based on a high volume of smaller orders. Affiliates can earn higher, uncapped commissions by promoting products from specific partner brands through "Brand Offers" or the "Shopee Commissions Xtra" program.^{2, 18} Tracking operates on a 7-day last-click attribution model for both app and web platforms.²

3.1.3 Affiliate Link Generation and Management

Shopee offers several methods for link generation. The most convenient is in-app generation, where the standard "share" link is automatically converted into a trackable affiliate link.² The web dashboard also features a "Custom Link" tool for converting any Shopee URL and advanced tools for generating links for specific "Shopee Offers" and "Brand Offers."^{2, 24} For tracking, custom Sub_ID tags can be added to links to monitor the performance of different campaigns or placements.²

3.1.4 Payouts, Thresholds, and Administrative Hurdles

Payouts are processed monthly via bank deposit, ShopeePay, GCash, or PayMaya.^{24, 25, 26} However, the most significant frustration reported by the community is the administrative bottleneck in getting payment and tax information approved. Affiliates must submit a valid Tax

Identification Number (TIN) and other documentation for verification before any commissions are released.^{25, 27} Numerous forum participants report extreme delays in this process, with accounts remaining unapproved for many months, effectively holding earned commissions in limbo.^{9, 24} This administrative friction creates a substantial "persistence barrier" that filters for only the most determined affiliates.

3.2 Analysis of the Lazada Philippines Affiliate Program (LazAffiliates)

The LazAffiliates program is perceived as a more complex but potentially more lucrative alternative, appealing to marketers with a more strategic, long-term approach.³

3.2.1 Onboarding Process and Approval

The application process, either direct or through networks like Involve Asia, is notably faster than Shopee's, with approvals typically granted within one to two business days.³ The program is open to anyone with an online presence, though high-tier opportunities may require follower minimums.¹⁶ BIR registration is often a requirement for commission payouts.³

3.2.2 Commission Structure and Earning Potential

Lazada's commission structure is more dynamic, with rates varying by customer status, product category, and purchase platform (web vs. app).^{3, 4, 31} Rates can reach as high as 10% for general products and are significantly amplified during mega sale campaigns (e.g., 11.11), where commissions have been reported to reach 18% to 36% for specific promotions.^{4, 6} A key distinction is that browser-based sales are commissioned by product category, while app-based sales are commissioned on the total order amount.³

3.2.3 Dual-Tracking Technology: Browser vs. App

Lazada employs a sophisticated dual-tracking system that creates distinct strategic opportunities.

1. **Browser Tracking:** A **30-day, last-click attribution** model is used. This long cookie duration is highly advantageous for affiliates creating long-form, SEO-driven content like blog reviews, as it captures purchases made weeks after the initial click.³
2. **App Tracking:** A **7-day, post-click attribution** model is used. Once a user clicks a link and opens the app, the affiliate's attribution is locked in for seven days for any purchase made, regardless of other links clicked subsequently. This model is powerful for driving impulse buys through viral, short-form content on platforms like TikTok.³

3.2.4 Payouts and Taxation

A minimum of PHP 1,200 in approved earnings is required for a monthly payout.³ Payments are made via bank transfer only, typically within 30 to 45 days of invoice generation.^{11, 20} Lazada automatically withholds taxes (5-10% for local banks).³ Despite the structured system, community members frequently report significant delays in receiving payments and unresponsive customer support, indicating that administrative friction is a cross-platform

issue.¹⁰

3.3 Dominant Strategic Approaches

Forum discussions reveal a consensus that success is not merely about link-sharing but about strategic content creation and community building.

3.3.1 Niche Specialization and Platform Selection

Experienced affiliates emphasize the importance of choosing a specific niche (e.g., budget-friendly skincare, home organization) to build authority and attract a dedicated audience.^{14, 34, 35} The choice of platform should align with the niche: blogs for SEO-driven content, YouTube for in-depth reviews, and TikTok or Instagram for visual, trend-based content.¹⁴

3.3.2 Principles of High-Conversion Content

The cornerstone of high conversion rates is audience trust, which is built through authentic, value-driven content. Promoting genuinely used and believed-in products is paramount.^{6, 7, 34} Effective content formats identified by the community include:

- **Honest Reviews and Comparisons:** In-depth analyses that help consumers make informed decisions.^{13, 34}
- **Curated "Finds" and Hauls:** Content framed around discovery, such as "Shopee Finds" or "Lazada Budol," which resonates with the Filipino consumer's value-seeking mindset.^{16, 36}
- **Tutorials and Demonstrations:** Content that shows a product in action, demonstrating its benefits rather than just listing its features.^{4, 13}

3.3.3 Platform-Specific Promotion Tactics

Successful affiliates tailor their promotional tactics to each platform's unique characteristics.

- **Facebook:** Strategies include sharing on Pages, creating Reels, and participating helpfully in relevant Groups rather than spamming links.^{24, 37, 38} The new Facebook Affiliate Partnership with Shopee is also noted as a promising integrated channel.^{39, 40}
- **TikTok & Instagram:** These platforms are ideal for short-form video, leveraging trends and popular sounds. A link aggregator in the bio is the standard practice for driving traffic.^{41, 42}
- **YouTube:** This platform is best for long-form, evergreen content like detailed reviews and tutorials. Links are placed prominently in the video description.^{13, 36}
- **Blogs:** The primary strategy is Search Engine Optimization (SEO), creating high-quality articles that attract organic traffic over the long term.^{7, 14}

3.4 Community-Reported Experiences

The forums provide an unvarnished look at both the potential rewards and the significant

challenges of affiliate marketing in the Philippines.

3.4.1 Documented Success Cases and Earning Potential

Numerous success stories validate the income-generating potential of these programs. Affiliates report achieving milestones such as earning one million pesos in total commissions from Lazada, building a dream home from affiliate income, and earning a passive income of ₱10,000–₱40,000 per month from Shopee with a relatively small TikTok following.^{45, 47, 48} One creator documented earning over ₱30,000 in their first two months with the new Facebook x Shopee partnership.⁴⁰

3.4.2 Common Pitfalls and Frustrations

Alongside success stories, several common frustrations are frequently discussed.

- **Administrative Hurdles:** The most prevalent complaint across both platforms is delayed payments. For Shopee, it is the months-long wait for payment/tax info verification.^{9, 24} For Lazada, it is the severe delay in the actual payout of approved commissions.¹⁰
- **Tracking Discrepancies:** Affiliates often report a perceived unreliability in tracking systems, with clicks and sales not appearing on their dashboards, leading to mistrust in the technology.^{24, 49}
- **Low Return on Effort:** Many beginners express frustration that the income generated does not justify the effort, with one user reporting earning only ₱5,000 after a year of consistent posting.⁴⁹
- **Terms of Service Violations:** Affiliates must navigate a strict set of rules, and violations such as using brand names in paid search ads or promoting on a personal Facebook profile can lead to account suspension.^{50, 51, 52}

3.4.3 Realistic Income Expectations

Based on community reports, a realistic income trajectory can be projected:

- **Beginner (1–6 Months):** ₱1,000 to ₱10,000 per month.^{14, 24}
- **Intermediate (6–18 Months):** ₱15,000 to ₱50,000 per month.¹⁴
- **Established Creator (18+ Months):** Well over ₱50,000 per month, with six-figure monthly incomes being achievable for top performers.^{24, 45}

3.5 Essential Communities and Forums

Active participation in online communities is cited as a key factor for success, providing access to peer support, troubleshooting, and strategic insights.

3.5.1 Reddit: Unfiltered Advice and Troubleshooting

Subreddits like **r/ShopeePH** and **r/phinvest** are invaluable hubs for candid discussions about payment delays, tax registration, and platform comparisons.^{9, 10, 27, 53} The global **r/Affiliatemarketing** subreddit provides broader knowledge on universal marketing

principles.⁵⁶

3.5.2 Facebook Groups: Niche Promotion and Networking

Facebook Groups are used in two ways: joining existing niche interest groups (e.g., "Home Buddies") to provide helpful, non-spammy recommendations, and joining dedicated affiliate groups (e.g., "Diskarteng Online Seller") for networking and strategy sharing.^{24, 37, 38}

3.5.3 International Forums for Advanced Strategy

For advanced technical knowledge, forums like **affLIFT**, **AffiliateFix**, and the **Warrior Forum** are recommended. While not specific to the Philippine market, they offer deep insights into universal topics like paid traffic, SEO, and conversion optimization.^{58, 59, 60}

4. Discussion

The findings indicate a clear divergence in the strategic positioning of Shopee and Lazada's affiliate programs. Shopee has established itself as the more accessible, beginner-friendly platform, characterized by a simple commission structure and an easy-to-use interface.¹ This lowers the barrier to entry for new content creators. However, this accessibility is tempered by a significant administrative bottleneck in its payment and tax verification process, which creates a "persistence barrier" that may deter casual participants.⁹

Lazada, conversely, presents a higher barrier to entry in terms of strategic complexity but offers a greater potential for high earnings. Its dual-tracking system, with a 30-day browser cookie, explicitly rewards affiliates who invest in long-form, SEO-driven content, a strategy with a longer-term payoff.³ This, combined with its rapid commission boosts during mega sales, makes it the preferred platform for data-driven marketers who can plan their content calendars around major e-commerce events.⁶

A crucial implication from the community analysis is the redefinition of success metrics. The prevailing sentiment suggests a move away from prioritizing raw follower counts and toward cultivating what can be termed "community trust velocity"—the speed at which an affiliate can build a loyal, engaged community that acts on their recommendations. This is supported by anecdotes of micro-influencers with high engagement out-earning macro-influencers with passive audiences.⁴⁸ Success, therefore, is a function of authenticity and value delivery, not just reach.

Finally, the widespread reports of administrative friction on both platforms highlight a significant operational risk for affiliates. Delayed payouts and unresponsive support channels can severely impact cash flow and test the resolve of even successful marketers. This suggests that while the front-end of affiliate marketing (content creation) is highly dynamic, the back-end (administration and payment) remains a critical point of friction in the ecosystem.

5. Conclusion

This analysis of online forums demonstrates that the affiliate programs of Shopee and Lazada represent a significant and accessible income-generating opportunity in the Philippines, but one that is fraught with distinct operational challenges. Shopee is perceived as the ideal starting point for beginners due to its simplicity, while Lazada offers a more complex but potentially more rewarding path for strategic, long-term content creators.

Despite their differences, the core driver of success on both platforms is the same: the ability to build and maintain audience trust through authentic, value-driven content. The community's experiences underscore that profitability is not a direct result of audience size but of the trust and engagement an affiliate cultivates.

However, the path to profitability is significantly hampered by administrative inefficiencies, particularly delays in payment and verification processes, which pose a material risk to affiliates. Consequently, aspiring marketers must enter this field with realistic expectations, a clear content strategy, and the persistence to navigate these back-end challenges. The most successful participants will be those who create compelling content and diligently manage the administrative aspects of their affiliate business. Future research should focus on quantitative analyses to validate the reported income levels and to measure the direct impact of administrative delays on affiliate retention and long-term earnings.

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